

Hahn-Soh-Lee

한-소-리

A Korean Romanization System for English Speakers

Version 2.0

This system developed over ten years of reflection on the limitations of existing Korean romanization for English speakers. The framework was refined and formalized in collaboration with AI (Claude, Anthropic, 2026). The linguistic instincts, observations, and core design decisions originate from a Korean American perspective – a viewpoint that existing official systems do not adequately represent.

Overview

Hahn-soh-lee (한-소-리, meaning “Korean sound”) is a romanization system designed from the ground up for English-speaking readers and speakers. Existing systems such as the Revised Romanization of 2000, while an improvement over earlier attempts, were developed primarily by native Korean speakers and reflect assumptions that do not translate cleanly to English phonetics. The result is a system that frequently misdirects English mouths toward incorrect pronunciations.

Hahn-soh-lee prioritizes four goals above all others:

- An English speaker should arrive at an approximately correct pronunciation on the first attempt, without prior instruction.
- The system must be internally consistent – one symbol, one sound, no exceptions within the core rules.
- **Reversibility** – any HSL word can be reconstructed back into Hangul exactly, because the mapping is one-to-one in both directions.
- **Keyboard Compatibility** – HSL sequences map directly to Korean keyboard input order. An English speaker who knows HSL can type Korean by following the romanization sequence. The Hangul block assembles automatically. $b + ah + n \rightarrow \text{ㅂ} + \text{ㅅ} + \text{ㄴ} \rightarrow \text{반}$

These principles work together. Revised Romanization and McCune-Reischauer are one-way streets – you cannot reliably reconstruct the original Hangul from their romanized forms, and they do not map to keyboard input order. Hahn-soh-lee is lossless in both directions and directly actionable at the keyboard.

$\text{훈} \rightarrow h + oo + n \rightarrow \text{hoon}$ ($\text{ㅂ} = h$, $\text{ㅅ} = oo$, $\text{ㄴ} = n$)

$\text{hoon} \rightarrow h + oo + n \rightarrow \text{훈}$ (fully reversible)

Formatting Conventions

Hyphens separate individual syllables within a word. Korean is a syllable-timed language – each syllable carries equal weight. The hyphen instructs the English reader to honor each syllable as a distinct unit rather than compressing them as English naturally tends to do.

Spaces mark word boundaries, identical to standard English usage.

Capital letters mark proper nouns, with capitalization applied to the first syllable only.

Boo-sahn (부산), Suh-ool (서울)

Core Consonants

Each consonant maps to a single Hahn-soh-lee symbol. The romanization follows the same left-to-right order as the Hangul block. A consonant combines with whatever vowel follows it – the consonant symbol stays constant, the vowel changes.

ㄹ + ㅏ = 라 = lah, ㄹ + ㅣ = 리 = lee, ㄹ + ㅓ = 러 = luh

ㄹ + ㅗ = 로 = loh, ㄹ + ㅜ = 루 = loo, ㄹ + ㅡ = 르 = leu

HANGUL	HSL	NOTES
ㄱ	g	Plain g – relaxed, no tension
ㄴ	n	Standard n
ㄷ	d	Plain d – relaxed
ㄹ	l	Light tap – like the medial l in “belly” or “dollar”; not the rounded American r
ㅁ	m	Standard m
ㅂ	b	Plain b – relaxed
ㅅ	s	Plain s; palatalizes to sh before ㅣ (see Rule 5)
ㅇ	(open)	Silent onset; acts as an open consonant – see Rule 6
ㅈ	j	Plain j – relaxed
ㅊ	ch	Aspirated – crisp puff of air
ㅋ	k	Aspirated k – crisp puff of air
ㅌ	t	Aspirated t – crisp puff of air
ㅍ	p	Aspirated p – crisp puff of air
ㅎ	h	Standard h

Core Vowels

Each vowel in Hahn-soh-lee maps to a single consistent sound. A trailing h is appended to vowels that would otherwise be ambiguous in English reading – it serves as a vowel anchor, ensuring the correct open sound rather than the closed or drifted English equivalent.

HANGUL	HSL	REFERENCE SOUND
아	ah	as in “ah!”
이	ee	as in “geese”
오	oh	as in “oak”
우	oo	as in “goose”
어	uh	as in the aw in “pawn”
으	eu	short, unrounded back vowel; closest approximation is the u in “put” said quickly
애	ey	open e – distinguished from ऐ (eh) to preserve reversibility; merged in modern speech
ऐ	eh	open e – distinguished from 애 (ey) to preserve reversibility; merged in modern speech

Writer’s Warning: ऐ looks like eh but is ey.

In modern Korean, 애 and ऐ are pronounced identically. Because of this, writers naturally reach for eh when romanizing either vowel. In Hahn-soh-lee, ऐ is eh and 애 is ey – the distinction exists purely for reversibility and keyboard fidelity, not phonetics. The difference is invisible to the ear and significant to the system. When in doubt, look at the Hangul character: ऐ gets eh, 애 gets ey.

Compound Vowels

Compound vowels are formed by prefixing y- to the base vowel. This convention mirrors the logic of other phonetically consistent systems such as Japanese Romaji.

HANGUL	HSL	FORMATION
야	yah	y + ah
여	yuh	y + uh
요	yoh	y + oh
유	yoo	y + oo (as in “goose”)
예	yeh	y + eh – paired with yey (애) to preserve reversibility
애	yey	y + ey – paired with yeh (예) to preserve reversibility

Modern Korean merges **예** and **애** to the same sound. Hahn-soh-lee preserves the distinction as yeh and yey to maintain reversibility and keyboard fidelity. The ear acquires the merger through exposure; the spelling preserves the Hangul structure.

Compound Vowels (W-Glide Family)

These seven vowels share a mechanism: a base vowel's rounding transitions into a second vowel, and at conversational speed the mouth compresses that transition into a w-glide. The spelling in the HSL Spelling column always encodes the underlying jamo structure, for reversibility and keyboard fidelity. The Fast-Speech Pronunciation column shows what an English speaker will actually hear – that is what the mouth arrives at without instruction, not the written form.

HANGUL	HSL	FAST-SPEECH PRONUNCIATION	NOTE
위	ooee	wee	—
의	euee	wee	—
웨	ooeh	weh	—
왜	ohey	weh	—
외	weh	weh	Exception — spelling follows ㅜ+ㅣ structure but pronunciation patterns with ㅞ/ㅟ, not ㅓㅣ. See note below.
와	ohah	wah	—
워	oouh	wuh	—

외 (weh) is the one exception. Historically ㅜ+ㅣ (ㅜ being one of these vowels) was a single front-rounded vowel – the same articulation as German ö – with the trailing ㅣ marking rounding rather than signaling a glide toward ee, the way it does in 위 and 의. When modern speech re-diphthongized that vowel, it resolved toward eh, not ee – landing in the same output family as 왜 and 웨 rather than with 위.

Worked Examples

Soft or null onsets (ㅇ, ㅎ) let the glide survive intact. Hard consonants crush the middle vowel – the onset and final vowel dominate, and the glide disappears. The pairs below show the same vowel under both conditions.

VOWEL	SOFT ONSET (GLIDE SURVIVES)	HARD ONSET (GLIDE CRUSHED)
위 (ooee)	위 – ooee (stomach) → wee	귀 – gooee (ear) → gee
의 (euee)	의사 – euee-sah (doctor) → wee-sah	no common real-word example – 의 rarely follows a hard onset in modern vocabulary
웨 (ooeh)	웨딩 – ooeh-deeng (wedding) → weh-deeng	궤도 – gooeh-doh (orbit) → gweh-doh
왜 (ohey)	왜 – ohey (why) → weh	괜찮아요 – goheyn-chahnh-ah-yoh (it's okay) → gweyn-chahnh-ah-yoh → geyn-chahnh-ah-yoh
외 (WEH)	외국 – weh-goog (foreign country)	된장 – dwehn-jahng (fermented soybean paste) → reduces to dehn-jahng in casual speech
와 (ohah)	화나서 – hohah-nah-suh (angry) → hwah-nah-suh	과일 – gohah-eel (fruit) → gwah-eel → gah-eel
워 (oouh)	반가워요 – bahn-gah-oouh-yoh (nice to meet you) → bahn-gah-wuh-yoh	줘 – joouh (give me) → jwuh → juh

Possessive marker: 나의 (my) contracts to neh in natural speech regardless of context. Write the canonical form; the ear acquires the contraction through exposure.

신 (ㅅ + 의) is a valid block but archaic and rarely encountered in modern Korean. It is omitted from this reference.

Phonetic Rules

Rule 1: 받침 (Bahd-cheem) Truncation

Final consonants in Korean – called 받침 (bahd-cheem) – never fully resolve. The mouth moves to the position of the consonant but does not complete the sound. The consonant is suspended rather than released.

닭 – dahlg (chicken – tongue moves toward l and k but neither fully lands)

듣 – deud (to hear – tongue reaches the d position and stops)

Korean consonants are suspended. English consonants are released. This suspension is the source of Korean's characteristic crispness.

Rule 2: Consonant Collision Sharpening

When a truncated 받침 consonant meets an identical consonant opening the following syllable, the two fuse and produce the tense (doubled) sound. This sharpening is a natural consequence of connected speech, not a separate phonetic rule.

d + d = dd b + b = bb g + g = gg s + s = ss j + j = jj

듣다 (to hear) – written deud-dah, spoken with the sharpened dd of the collision

Rule 3: Voiced Final Consonants

Final consonants are written in their voiced form throughout Hahn-soh-lee – d, b, g, s – because they voice naturally when followed by a vowel-initial syllable. In isolation, these consonants soften toward their unvoiced counterparts t, p, k, and d respectively. ㄱ as a final consonant follows the same pattern – written as s, but truncates and voices toward d in speech. The ear acquires this softening naturally without instruction.

밥 – bahb (rice – voiced b in writing; softens toward p in isolation)

닭 – dahlg (chicken – voiced g; softens in isolation)

입 – eeb (mouth – voiced b in writing; softens toward p in isolation)

뜻 – ddeus (meaning/intent – written s; voices toward d before next syllable)

Rule 4: Tense vs. Aspirated Consonants

Korean distinguishes three forms of most consonants. English has only one form of each, which makes tense and aspirated consonants easy to confuse. Both sound sharp to an English ear – the distinction is air.

Plain – relaxed, no special air or tension: b, d, g, j, s

Tense – muscle tension, no air, sharp and clipped. Written as doubled consonants: bb, dd, gg, jj, ss

Aspirated – puff of air, crisp and open. Written as single consonants: ch, k, t, p

Practical test: hold your hand in front of your lips. Aspirated consonants move air. Tense consonants do not.

짜다 – jjah-dah (salty – tense 짜, clipped and sharp, no air)

반찬 – bahn-chahn (side dishes – aspirated ㄷ, crisp with a puff of air)

Tense Consonant Reference

The complete set of tense consonants and their Hahn-soh-lee representations:

HANGUL	HSL	EXAMPLE
ㅈㅈ	jj	짜다 – jjah-dah (salty)
ㅂㅂ	bb	뉴 – bbyuh (bone)
ㄱㄱ	gg	까다 – ggah-dah (to peel)
ㄷㄷ	dd	따뜻하다 – ddah-ddeus-hah-dah (warm) (in ddeus the s sounds like a d per Rule 3)
ㅅㅅ	ss	쓰다 – sseu-dah (bitter)

Rule 5: ㅅ Palatalization Before ㅣ

ㅅ palatalizes before ㅣ, producing a sh onset rather than plain s.

ㅅ + ㅣ = shee

ㅆ + ㅣ = ssee (tense consonant resists palatalization; the ss articulation overrides the sh shift)

Rule 6: ㅇ Vowel Pull

ㅇ as a syllable onset is a silent open consonant. When preceded by a 받침, it pulls that final consonant into itself, voicing it as its own onset in connected speech. The romanization preserves the written structure – the ear applies the pull naturally.

밥이 – written bahb-ee, spoken bah-bee

먹어 – written muhg-uh, spoken muh-guh

The writing never changes – HSL always reflects the true Hangul structure. The pull is a spoken behavior, not a spelling rule. This preserves full reversibility: bahb-ee maps back to 밥이 without ambiguity.

Rule 7: ㅇ Glide Activation

ㅇ and ㅎ are soft consonants – both produced at the open glottis with no tongue or lip obstruction. Notice that ㅎ is visually ㅇ with a stroke added: the same open circle, with breath on top. This is not coincidence – Hangul’s design reflects articulation directly.

Before compound vowels (외, 위, 의), the w glide is not written – it is generated by coarticulation. The base vowel’s rounding (oh, oo, eu) transitions into ee, and the mouth produces the w naturally at speed. Soft onsets (ㅇ, ㅎ) allow this transition to complete fully. Hard consonants block it – the middle vowel is suppressed and the final sound is determined by what the onset and base vowel produce together. King Sejong encoded this behavior directly into Hangul’s architecture: soft consonants share the open glottal base and let the vowel express itself; hard consonants close the airway before the glide can form.

ㅇ + ㅣ = 외 = weh

(null onset – oh rounding generates w glide → weh)

ㅎ + ㅣ = 회 = hweh

(ㅎ is ㅇ + breath – glide survives → hweh)

ㄷ + ㅣ = 댜 = dweh

(hard consonant – oh crushed, ee pulls to eh → deh)

The w is always written in HSL regardless of the onset consonant. Speech reduction is acquired through exposure. The spelling preserves full reversibility.

Rule 8: 받침 ㅇ – The ng Final

ㅇ has two identities depending on its position in the syllable block. As an onset, it is silent. As a final consonant (받침), it produces ng – the same ng as in “ring” or “song.”

This is the only context in which ㅇ carries audible sound.

방 – bahng (room)

가방 – gah-bahng (bag)

한강 – Hahn-gahng (Han River, Seoul)

Rule 9: ㅎ 받침 Absorption

ㅎ as a 받침 (final consonant) is soft and yields to adjacent hard consonants. When a hard consonant also occupies a 받침 position in the same syllable, the hard consonant takes the transfer to the following ㅇ onset, and ㅎ is absorbed entirely.

The underlying principle is the same as Rule 7: ㅎ is the most yielding consonant in the system. As an onset it lets glides pass through; as a 받침 it surrenders the transfer to any hard consonant sharing its syllable.

괜찮아요 – goheyn-chahnh-ah-yoh

찮 = ㄷ + ㅎ 받침. ㄷ (ㄷ 받침) is the hard consonant – it transfers.

ㅎ is absorbed. Spoken: gweyn-chahnh-nah-yoh.

좋은 – johh-eun

ㅎ alone as 받침, followed by ㅇ onset – ㅎ transfers normally.

Spoken: joh-heun.

Note: This rule is documented from a limited set of examples and has not been exhaustively stress-tested. Additional cases may refine or extend it.

Surname Exception: 이 (Lee)

The vowel 이| is represented as ee throughout Hahn-soh-lee. However, as a surname, the romanization Lee is the accepted exception. The double-e representation ee is phonetically accurate but visually awkward in English and has historically caused confusion.

Lee has been naturally standardized through generations of Korean American usage and is universally recognized by English speakers. Hahn-soh-lee honors this organic correction.